

Dousing the flames

A firefighting plane, called an air tanker, pours retardant over areas where the fire is approaching in a forest near Colfax in California, in 2014. Although it can look like a powder when dropped, the retardant is a liquid. It contains a thickener that helps it stick to objects and a colored dye that shows where it lands.



A chemical called red oxide gives the retardant its red color, which helps the pilot see where they have already dropped the retardant.



FIRE EXTINGUISHERS

A small-scale fire can be stopped using a fire extinguisher. This acts like a spray can and quickly expels its contents directly onto a fire. Some contain water, to remove heat, while others can contain carbon dioxide or other fire retardants. Different types of extinguisher are used for different types of fire.